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IRAN TARGETS U.S. MILITARY SITES IN KUWAIT, BAHRAIN

Ceasefire falters as Iran and US exchange fresh strikes, threats

US may militarily complete the job, if that happens, Iran will no longer exist: Trump

Tala Ramadan, Eman Abouhassira & Phil Stewart
Dubai, Washington, June 28

IRAN LAUNCHED missiles and drones at US military sites in Kuwait and Bahrain early on Sunday, shortly after President Donald Trump threatened to wipe out the Iranian leadership if they did not stick to the interim agreement to end their war.

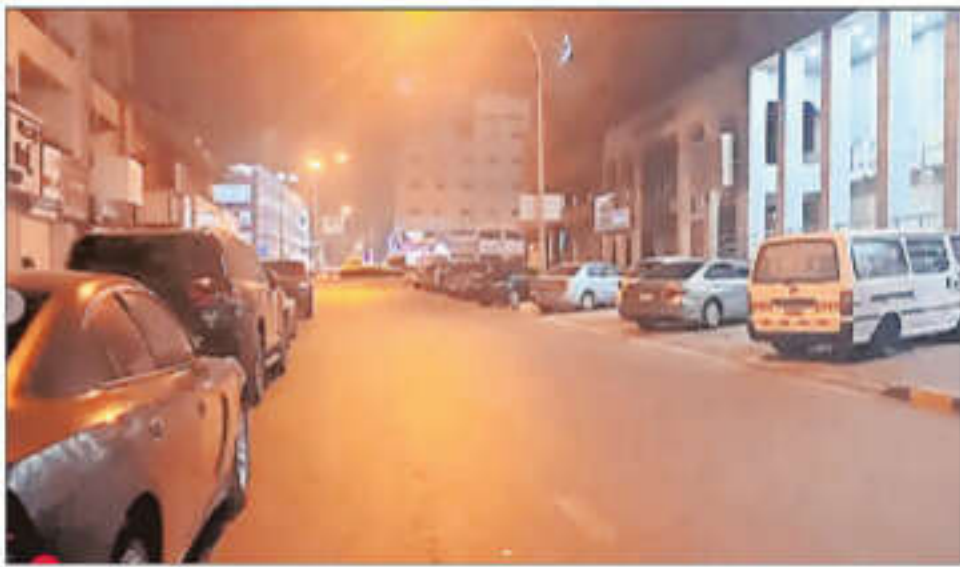
Israel said on Sunday it had struck Iran-backed armed Hezbollah militants in Lebanon on Saturday, just a day after it agreed to the latest ceasefire deal with Lebanon to calm

THE WORLD PAGE 14

TRUMP PRESSES SYRIA TO TAKE ON HEZBOLLAH; ISRAEL ALARMED

fighting that Iran says must end if the wider agreement is to stick.

The US military said earlier it had struck Iran again, hours after a tanker was hit in the Strait of Hormuz, the world's most important energy shipping route, which Tehran has



Sirens sounded in Kuwait City early Sunday after Kuwait said Iran had fired drones and missiles. AP

largely closed for most of the conflict. "There may come a point when we are no longer able to be reasonable, and will be forced to militarily complete the job that we very success-

fully started," Trump said on social media. "If that happens, the Islamic Republic of Iran will no longer exist!" he added.

The 14-point interim peace accord was meant to halt the

fighting, which the US and Israel started on February 28, and reopen the strait while talks proceeded on issues such as Iran's nuclear programme.

One round of mediated talks, led by US Vice President JD Vance and Iran's Parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf, was held in Switzerland a week ago and Washington waived sanctions on Tehran, but fighting has since resumed and intensified.

About an hour after Trump's post, Kuwait's army said its air defences were responding to missile and drone attacks, while Bahrain said sirens had sounded there. Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said in a statement its Navy and Air Force had

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

MODI AWARDED 'GUARDIAN OF THE BLUE HORIZON' TITLE BY SEYCHELLES



PM Narendra Modi with Speaker Azarel Ernesta at the National Assembly of Seychelles in Victoria, Sunday. ANI RELATED REPORT, P 6

Indian Ocean links India, Seychelles... want to make it ocean of opportunity: PM

In address to National Assembly, Modi calls for 'climate justice' for Global South

Divya A
New Delhi, June 28

INDIA ENVISIONS an Indian Ocean where maritime security is ensured alongside economic prosperity and where partnership is not based on size, but on mutual respect and trust, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who is on a three-day visit to Seychelles, said on Sunday.

"Our vision is to make the Indian Ocean an Ocean of Opportunity," he said, after delegation-level talks with Seychelles President Patrick Herminie, during which the two sides re-

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



viewed the full spectrum of bilateral cooperation and exchanged views on regional and international issues of mutual interest, including challenges in the Indian Ocean Region like illegal fishing, drug trafficking and piracy.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Army set to establish, operationalise first Integrated Battle Groups next month

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 28

THE ARMY is set to establish and operationalise its first Integrated Battle Groups (IBG) by next month, marking a significant transformation under which self-contained, agile, brigade-sized fighting units will be carved out of the Panagarh-based XVII Corps — the mountain strike corps (MSC) facing China — for swift deployment in mountainous areas, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Sources privy to the development told *The Indian Express* that the earlier plan was to create four IBGs under the two divisions operating under the XVII MSC — the 59 Division and the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Self-contained, rapid deployment

Each IBG, comprising over 5,000 troops, will have battalions of infantry, artillery regiments, Corps of Electronics and Mechanical Engineers, Combat Engineers, Army Service Corps and a field hospital. The IBGs will be especially crucial in mountainous terrains, as their agile nature allows rapid deployment, eliminating the wait for the entire corps to mobilise.

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 29~06~2026

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All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

US-Iran

launched missile and drone operations targeting US military sites in Kuwait and Bahrain.

The Guards said US strikes had violated the ceasefire and “will result in the complete halt of all diplomatic processes”, state-run *Press TV* said. The IRGC Navy command said American bases in the region “will experience hell in the coming days”. A US official, confirming Iran had targeted US facilities, told *Reuters* there were no reported US casualties or major damage to US sites in the Middle East but the situation was still unfolding.

Hours later, alarms sounded for a second time in Bahrain, where authorities said an Iranian attack damaged a residential building in Muharraq province, with no casualties reported. Bahrain urged the UN Security Council to hold an urgent session to hold Iran accountable.

The Kuwaiti Army said it had intercepted two ballistic missiles with no damage or casualties. Separately, Qatar said one of its nationals had died after sustaining injuries from shrapnel aboard a vessel that had gone missing on Saturday. A second person was injured in the inci-

dent, which was due to “military operations in the area”, the interior ministry said, without giving a location or apportioning blame.

US Central Command said its forces had carried out the new strikes after a Panama-flagged tanker was attacked by an Iranian drone on Saturday. “Iran was given a chance to honor the ceasefire agreement but elected not to,” Central Command said in a statement. US strikes were “in direct response to continued Iranian aggression against commercial shipping” and targeted Iranian military surveillance, communications, air defence, drone storage and mine-laying facilities, it said.

Explosions were heard in Sirik in southern Iran, Iranian state broadcaster IRIB said without providing details. The Guards said, “America’s blind shots at Sirik will not resolve our dominance over the Strait of Hormuz. But our shots at violators will remind the rest of the vessels of the clear passage route.”

Saturday’s tanker attack in the strait followed one on a cargo ship on Thursday that triggered the latest escalation. Iran’s Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said responsibility for returning maritime traffic in the strait to pre-war levels lay solely with

Tehran and urged others not to intervene “in Iran’s administration of the strait”.

Washington has been promoting a southern lane along the coast of Oman, while Tehran, which ultimately aims to charge fees for use of the strait, wants ships to use a northern route through its waters and under its control.

Hundreds of ships stranded in the strait, including tankers laden with oil, began leaving over the past two weeks, sending oil prices back close to pre-war levels. Even as attacks continued on Sunday morning, CMA CGM’s Galapagos container ship exited the strait in what the shipping giant called “an important milestone in a regional context”.

In Lebanon, Israel said on Sunday it had killed Hezbollah militants armed with rocket-propelled grenades and struck a rocket launcher in the Nabatieh area. There was no immediate response from Hezbollah.

Israel, which is not a party to the US-Iran deal, and Lebanon have repeatedly agreed to US-brokered ceasefires, the latest on Friday. But these have had limited effect, with Israel insisting it will not withdraw from Lebanese territory it has seized and Hezbollah rejecting calls to give up its arms as long as Israeli troops remain in place. **REUTERS**

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RG9mljMzg1

Seychelles

Addressing the National Assembly later in the day, Modi said the Global South, especially island nations, was the most impacted by climate change, and called for climate action guided by “fairness, responsibility and equity”. He said those who had contributed the least to climate change should not bear the greatest burden of its consequences. “This is the essence of climate justice,” he said.

Modi, the guest of honour for Seychelles’ National Day celebrations, was also conferred the honorary ‘Guardian of the Blue Horizon’ title for his commitment to environmental conservation and sustainable development.

The key outcomes of talks between the two sides reflected the broadening of New Delhi’s engagement with the strategically located Indian Ocean archipelagic nation, expanding cooperation across defence and maritime security to connectivity, capacity building, development partnership, digital payments, space, healthcare, agriculture and education.

“We believe the Indian Ocean is our shared home. Its security, sustainability and prosperity are our shared responsibility,” Modi said after the talks. He said the two sides discussed making bilateral economic cooperation more resilient and future-ready.

“We will continue to explore new opportunities for the industries of both our countries. Work will also be done to enhance connectivity between India and Seychelles,” he said.

In his statement, Herminie said: “As maritime neighbours, security in the Indian Ocean Region remains central to our relationship. We reaffirmed Seychelles’ special place in India’s Mahasagar vision. We affirmed our commitment to counter piracy, drug trafficking, illegal fishing, and cross-border crime.”

He also acknowledged India’s support in strengthening the country’s maritime capabilities through surveillance, hydrography and defence capacity building.

“Development partnership

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has been a strong pillar of India-Seychelles relations, guided by Seychelles’ priorities. I was especially pleased to pursue discussions on the announcement of the Special Economic Package of \$175 million (Rs 1,651 crore) from the Government of India, comprising \$125 million in a rupee-denominated Line of Credit and \$50 million in grant assistance,” Herminie said.

In his address to the National Assembly later in the day, Modi again underlined the shared vision regarding the security and sustainability of the Indian Ocean, affirming that it “connects” the two countries.

Calling it his “special honour” to be the first Indian PM to address the Assembly, he said: “The Indian Ocean does not separate India and Seychelles. It connects us. That is why we meet not as strangers, but as old friends.”

“As maritime neighbours, we recognise that the security of one adds to the security of the other. The prosperity of one contributes to the prosperity of the other. The stability of the region benefits us all,” he said. “Our cooperation in maritime security and capacity building reflects our shared commitment to a safer and more secure Indian Ocean Region,” he added.

He said the Global South, especially island nations, was bearing the brunt of climate change, as he underlined the need for equitable climate action. “The Global South, and especially the island nations, are the most impacted by climate change. Its effects are already visible on our coastlines, in the marine ecosystem, in weather patterns, and in our communities,” he said.

He further said that India and Seychelles shared the vision of a world where development was more inclusive and reaffirmed their commitment to advancing the interests of the Global South. “This is the spirit that unites the Global South. And this is the vision that India and Seychelles will continue to advance together,” he said.

“The connections between our cultures are visible in everyday life. They can be felt in the flavours of kharik, samosa and chutney. They can be found in the celebrations of Deepavali, Thai Pongal, and the garba

dance during Navratri. This is the Creole spirit that gives us great confidence in the future of our friendship,” Modi said.

Noting that Seychelles’ maritime territory is spread over 1.4 million square kilometres of the western Indian Ocean, Modi said this makes it “not a small island State but a large ocean country.”

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the outcomes of the talks between the two sides included an extradition treaty aimed at strengthening cross-border crime cooperation, an agreement on cooperation in the peaceful uses of outer space, an agreement to advance UPI-based digital payments in Seychelles, an umbrella line of credit agreement with the Export-Import Bank of India, and an agreement for preliminary preparations for a new Seychelles National Hospital.

Responding to a question at a media briefing on speculation over India’s role on Assumption Island, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said the issue was not specifically discussed. But, he said, India would be “open to hearing about this” should Seychelles government officials raise the matter.

“Any project that we undertake in Seychelles or for that matter any foreign country, is ultimately guided by the priorities and the interests of the host government and the authorities in the host country,” he said.

The two sides also announced the gifting of a fast patrol vessel to Seychelles, the handover of 10 utility vehicles and five Laser Radial class boats to the Seychelles Defence Force, the completion of the refit of PS Zoroaster for the Seychelles Coast Guard and the upgradation of a Dornier aircraft with a glass cockpit.

Other development initiatives included the handover of six ambulances, 500 metric tonnes of rice and 8,500 metric tonnes of cement, the launch of a commemorative logo marking 50 years of diplomatic relations and the virtual ground-breaking ceremony for a Professional and Technical Education Centre, the MEA said on X.

Meanwhile, Leader of Opposition of Seychelles, Bernard Georges, also called on Modi.

First IBG next month

23 Division — by September. However, this is now learnt to have been advanced to July 1.

The Indian Express had first reported in January this year that the long-drawn plans to create IBGs had gathered pace and may be implemented soon.

According to the existing plans, four IBGs and a fire support group will be created under the XVII MSC. Each of the five will be commanded by a Major General rank officer. Each IBG will comprise over 5,000 troops, with 12-13 units, and may have a Brigadier-rank officer as the Chief Operations Officer.

While the four IBGs will be created from the two divisions of the XVII MSC, the fire support group comprising artillery platoons will likely operate directly under the corps headquarters. The newly created Divyastra batteries of the Army could be placed under this group.

Each IBG will have battalions of infantry, artillery regiments, as well as elements of the Corps of Electronics and Mech-

anical Engineers (EME), Combat Engineers, Army Service Corps, and a field hospital or others.

The creation of the IBGs is part of a larger restructuring plan of the Army, which includes the creation of Bhairav battalions, Rudra brigades, Divyastra batteries and Shaktibaan units. The Rudra brigades, commanded by a Brigadier, will also have multiple elements, but will be dependent on the division for more support. IBGs will be larger in size and more self-contained and independent in nature.

These will be the first IBGs of the Army -- a move proposed in one of the four studies initiated by then Army Chief General Bipin Rawat on the restructuring of the Army. The plans to establish IBGs have been under discussion for about seven years now. These plans of capability development are premised on capacity, and not a threat-based model.

The IBGs would be capable of carrying out both offensive

and defensive roles against an adversary’s attack.

The concept was test-bedded at the IX Corps on the western border with Pakistan around 2019, but remains to be implemented. The IBG concept was also experimented with multiple exercises conducted in the eastern theatre, including Exercise Him Vijay in 2019.

The IBGs can be rapidly deployed in the mountainous areas, thus reducing the time for an entire corps to mobilise. A corps comprises up to a lakh troops and takes a longer time to get deployed.

Sources had earlier indicated that the strength of an IBG lies in its swift application and flexible nature, and its creation would ensure better cohesiveness for various combined arms operations. Once established, they can also be deployed under specific theatre commands.

Over the last decade, China, too, has transitioned from older divisions to smaller, more versatile Combined Arms Brigades (CABs), integrated with tanks, artillery, air defence and support units, designed for joint operations.

Smart buildings that alert the Fire Control Room even before someone can dial the fire helpline number 101.

Artificial intelligence systems that identify and dispatch the nearest available fire truck to the location within seconds.

Drones that stream live visuals to fire-fighters as they race to the scene.

These are among the proposals in a 25-year roadmap drawn up by the Delhi Fire Services (DFS), a blueprint for the future of firefighting in the Capital that calls for a significant expansion in the number of fire stations, and the recruitment of more than 25,000 additional personnel over the next quarter century.

The plan has been drawn up in response to the rapid and continuous expansion of the city, its changing lifestyles, the use of modern construction material that often overlooks fire safety considerations, and increasingly complex building designs which have stretched the DFS's ability to respond to emergencies – even as the numbers of fire incidents and emergency calls continue to rise every year. (See table)

According to the DFS, the changing nature of fires has exposed critical gaps in infrastructure, manpower, communication systems and emergency response — shortcomings that the department says call for a unified, technology-driven, fire safety framework for the capital.

“The changing nature of fire emergencies necessitates a paradigm shift in the functioning of the fire service,” the document states. The roadmap, it says, seeks to move the DFS from a largely reactive fire-fighting system to one that is centred on prevention and early detection of fires.

Three tragedies, one reckoning

The plan was prepared in the aftermath of the Palam, Vivek Vihar, and Malviya Nagar fires, which together claimed more than four dozen lives in March, May, and June this year, and laid bare serious gaps in Delhi's emergency response system, officials said. The 23-page blueprint, accessed by *The Indian Express*, was drawn up after Chief Minister Rekha Gupta directed relevant government departments to formulate a long-term firefighting master plan to tackle similar incidents in the future.

The document has proposed a series of measures aimed at cutting casualties and building a faster, technology-driven emergency response system — they include mandatory smoke detectors and sprinkler systems, drones for fire assessment, Internet of Things (IoT)-enabled fire alerts, an expanded network of fire stations, specialised response units, a massive modernisation of equipment, and large-scale recruitment of Fire personnel.

DFS officials said the plan has been submitted with timelines of five, 10, 15, and 25 years, aimed at bringing Delhi's fire and emergency response up to “an advanced, global standard”.

A city outgrowing its fire cover

At the heart of the plan is a stark reckoning: For its size, the capital of India simply does not have enough fire stations.

Delhi is currently served by 71 fire stations, a third short of the requirement of 107 identified by the global tech solutions company RMSI in a 2011 risk analysis commissioned by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs. The firefighting master plan has proposed that the number of fire stations be raised to 100 by 2030, 120 by 2032, and to 196 by 2051, with 49 new stations coming up in the first six years alone, followed by four a year over the rest of the 25-year horizon.

The document envisages a response time of five minutes, even though it concedes that given the pace of the city's growth, “achieving [that]...continues to remain a distant goal”. The more immediate aim, officials said, is to bring the average response time down from the current 12-15 minutes to under seven minutes in congested areas.

The numbers behind the crisis

DFS data show the scale of the challenge. Emergency calls have jumped 135 per cent over the past two decades, from 15,718 in 2007-08 to 36,877 in 2025-26. Annual casualties have climbed even faster — up 4.2 times, from 351 to about 1,480 over the same period.

Most fire deaths, the document notes, occur from smoke inhalation within the first three to five minutes of an incident — a survival window that has shrunk in recent years because of changing building designs, the spread of modern construction materials and interior finishes, and contemporary living styles. Reducing fire incidents in the capital by 2030 is listed as a key objective of the plan.

An undermanned, overstretched force

The manpower numbers are perhaps the most alarming presented in the plan. The DFS has projected a need for 9,223 additional personnel over the next three years simply to roll out the long-pending “1+1” duty system — 24 hours on duty, 24 hours off — across its 71 existing stations.

Under the present arrangement, operational staff work 24-hour shifts followed by 24 hours off, while officers do 72 hours on duty for every 24 off, the document notes.

According to the department's own assessment, its current sanctioned strength of 3,051 personnel is barely a quarter of the



THE NEXT 25 YEARS

DELHI'S NEW FIREFIGHTING PLAN

A 23-page blueprint accessed by *The Indian Express* acknowledges that the Capital's unplanned growth has outpaced its firefighting capacity. It charts a 25-year fix — built around AI dispatch, drones, and a near-tripling of fire stations, reports Gayathri Mani

Delhi Fire Services' Expansion Plan

Key Objectives

CUTTING average response time in congested areas from 12-15 mins to less than 7 mins.

REDUCING fire deaths, most of which occur due to smoke inhalation within 3-5 mins.

BRINGING DOWN incidents of industrial and residential fires.

EXPANDING fire station network to 100 stations by 2030 to match Delhi's growing population and urban density.

STRENGTHENING fire safety by making smoke detectors and automatic sprinklers mandatory in new buildings this year; in existing buildings by 2030. Higher fire loads traced to modern interiors, synthetic furnishings and upholstery, toxic smoke.

PIVOTING to preventive deployment from reactive response through use of data-driven planning; aim to reduce major ('Make-6'-level and above) fires.

INTEGRATING automated fire detection at Fire Control Room with nearest fire station to cut delays in manual reporting.



12,274 required to run the proposed duty pattern without interruption — a roughly three-fold shortfall that would make this one of the largest recruitment drives ever proposed for the city's fire services. The gap is the widest among fire operators, the personnel who drive and operate fire engines, ladder trucks, and specialized rescue equipment — the DFS needs 9,553 of them but has only 2,367, leaving a shortfall of 7,186.

Wiring buildings to the Fire Brigade

A central plank of the long-term plan is to connect buildings directly to the Fire Control Room. Under a proposed IoT-based smart building integration system, to be rolled out over the next five to 10 years, buildings fitted with smoke detectors, sprinklers and hydrant systems would be linked to the Control Room through web-based technology — enabling real-time monitoring, faster alerts, and continuous health-checks on a building's fire safety systems to catch faults early.

The DFS has also proposed to make smoke detectors and automatic sprinkler systems mandatory in all upcoming buildings by 2026, and in all existing buildings by 2030.

“Valuable response time is often lost be-

tween the occurrence of a fire and its detection by occupants or observers, resulting in delayed reporting...and slower mobilisation,” the plan notes, arguing that a shift to automated detection and communication can sharply cut this delay.

Closer to the present, the DFS is upgrading its main Fire Control Room and equipping fire engines with Mobile Data Terminals for faster, real-time transmission of incident details — a modernisation drive officials say is already under way and expected to be completed within the current financial year. Looking further out, the plan envisages each of the DFS's operational divisions getting its own fully automated Fire Control Room within 15 years, working in tandem with the main control room to create a decentralised but integrated communication network across the city.

Drones, dead zones and a broken radio network

The 15-year plan also proposes inducting drones into the firefighting fleet, with live aerial feeds beamed directly to the Fire Control Room — giving senior officers a real-time view of how a fire is spreading, where the vulnerable zones are, and how best to deploy resources on the ground.

That vision contrasts starkly with the Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1



Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

DFS's account of its present-day communication network, which the document describes in unflattering terms. Fire stations in the outer parts of the city have become “virtual dead zones”, it says, with little or no wireless coverage, severely hampering co-ordination during emergencies.

The department currently relies on a patchwork of mobile and static wireless sets, hand-held walkie-talkies, towers and repeaters — of which, the DFS says, only one repeater is fully functional.

“The present arrangement suffers from signal obstruction, inadequate coverage in high-rise and basement structures, dependency on outdated analog systems, and the absence of resilient disaster communication capability,” the document states.

The fleet, the phases, and a new address

The plan also envisages a stronger first-response fleet. Quick Response Vehicles (QRVs), built for rapid initial response, especially in dense, congested neighbourhoods, are to be doubled from 100 to 200 by 2032, growing by 10 vehicles a year thereafter as a dedicated QRV wing.

The 25-year roadmap itself is broken into four phases: rapid expansion in the first five years; consolidation and upgradation over

Hands on hoses, boots on ground, next 25 years

Building Muscle 2026

3,051 personnel	191 fire appliances (145 pumping units, 46 specialised units)	100 Quick Response Vehicles (QRVs)
71 fire stations		
20 firefighting motorcycles	35 Command & Control Vehicles (CCVs)	



NEXT 3 YEARS

9,223 posts to be filled | 368 fire appliances

- Shortage of pumping units; aerial ladders; hydraulic platforms; rescue, Hazmat and command vehicles to be addressed

BY 2032

120 fire stations (49 new)	200 QRVs
960 fire appliances (720 pumping units, 240 specialised units)	130 firefighting motorcycles /e-bikes
	404 CCVs

2032 ONWARDS

4 new fire stations a year, based on projected annual addition of 10 lakh to population

BY 2041

156 fire stations	290 QRVs
1,248 fire appliances	175 firefighting motorcycles/e-bikes

BY 2051

28,783 personnel	390 QRVs
196 fire stations	225 firefighting motorcycles/e-bikes
1,568 fire appliances (1,176 pumping units, 392 specialised units)	8-HR, 3-SHIFT workdays eventually

the next five; optimisation and specialisation between years 11 and 15; and, in the final phase, the development of modern, GIS-enabled emergency hubs.

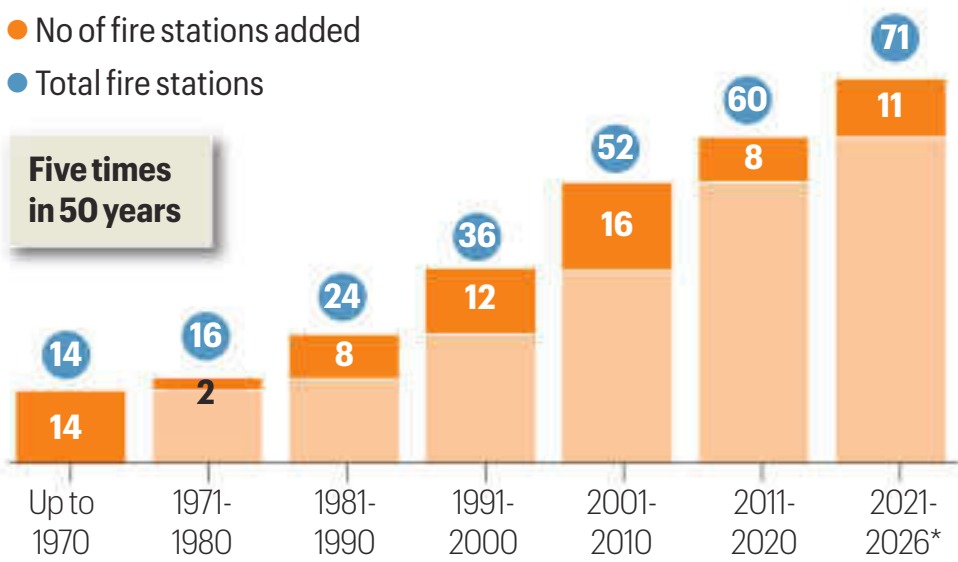
To find space for the new stations, the DFS has approached the DDA, the PWD and the Revenue Department for land, and has separately proposed a new headquarters at Connaught Place, to be built through NBCC — a proposal that will go before the Cabinet on its own.

Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood, who attended a high-level meeting chaired by the Chief Minister after the Palam and Vivek Vihar fires, said the government planned to strengthen the DFS over the next 25 years “with modern machinery and advanced firefighting equipment”.

Asked about the plan, Sood said: “We have received the draft firefighting master plan from the DFS and are examining it.”

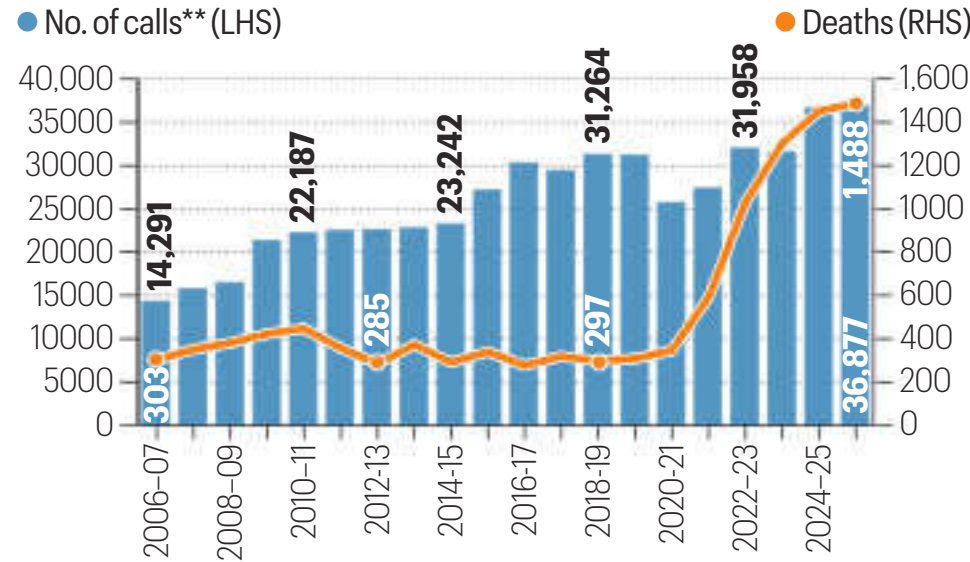
A senior DFS official said the department had been specifically asked to draw up a fire master plan for the next 25 years. “DFS has prepared a roadmap for strengthening the Delhi Fire Service to meet the immediate demands of fire emergency response and long-term plans for 10, 15 and 25 years. The report has been submitted to the Home department and the government,” the official said.

• Number of fire stations (1970-Present)



*AT PRESENT

• Number of calls (2006-07-Present)



**INCLUDES CALLS RELATING TO SUICIDES, DROWNING, ACCIDENTS, BIRD RESCUES

PM: From seas to skies, India is becoming secure & self-reliant

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 28

Referring to his recent Kolkata visit, where he commissioned three indigenously designed and built Naval ships — INS Dunagiri, INS Sanshodhak and INS Agray — he said, “Everything, from the design

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://>

The Central Sanskrit University in Delhi launching a B Tech programme in AI and data science is a crucial step towards integrating modern technology with India's traditional knowledge, the PM said, adding that the programme will facilitate the development of new AI tools for Indian languages and accelerate the digitisation and preservation of ancient texts and manuscripts.

Boost to strategic ties as Modi meets Mauritius PM in Seychelles



PM Narendra Modi with his Mauritius counterpart Navinchandra Ramgoolam in Seychelles on Sunday. PTI

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 28

Modi had visited Mauritius in March last year at the invitation of PM Ramgoolam to participate, as the Chief Guest, at their 57th National Day celebration.

PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI

AFTER MEETING MAURITIUS COUNTERPART NAVINCHANDRA RAMGOOLAM

On Sunday, Prime Minister Modi underscored the importance attached by India to the development and progress of Mauritius — noting that the ongoing bilateral projects will contribute to Mauritius's healthcare, connectivity, sustainable development and blue economy. India supports Mauritius through extensive grant and Line of Credit (LoC) funding.

The two leaders agreed on the significance of the India-Mauritius Enhanced Strategic Partnership under India's Vision MAHASAGAR and Neighbourhood First policy, and their shared commitment to the Global South. Modi said on X, "Had an excellent meeting with Dr. Navinchandra Ramgoolam, the Prime Minister of Mauritius... We discussed ways to strengthen the India-Mauritius partnership. The progress being made across every area of our Enhanced Strategic Partnership is a matter of satisfaction for us."

Rain havoc: Railway bridge collapses in Assam, flash floods in Arunachal

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, June 28

HEAVY RAINFALL has wreaked havoc on infrastructure across Arunachal Pradesh and Assam, including the collapse of a large portion of a railway bridge in Assam's Dhemaji district, affecting the movement of trains in the area.

As river waters swelled in Upper Assam's Dhemaji district with the rainfall there exceeding 110 mm in 24 hours, the railway bridge collapsed, leading to the suspension of train operations between Murkongselek and Silapathar under Tinsukia division.

"This bridge, constructed in 1965 and later converted to broad gauge, was in good and safe condition, but due to the washing away of a large portion of the river bank during the heavy rains, one of its piers became unstable. There is no damage to any train or injury to any person. This is a low-traffic branch line, and all traffic was already stopped beforehand due to the heavy flooding of the river," said a Northeast Frontier Railways official.

The Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) estimated that, as of Sunday evening, around 15,483 people were affected by flooding in Dhemaji, with the total across Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>



A railway bridge that collapsed in Assam's Dhemaji district. EXPRESS

the state placed at 22,124.

"Since the flood situation has unfolded in Dhemaji, I've been closely monitoring the situation. We are deeply saddened by the impact it has had on the lives of our people and in this difficult time, we stand firmly with them. We are deploying a whole-of-government approach and mobilising all our resources to prioritise the immediate safety and long-term rehabilitation of all families affected," said Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma.

Flash floods continue in Arunachal Pradesh

In neighbouring Arunachal Pradesh, heavy rainfall and flash floods continue to lead to landslides across different parts of the state, severely affecting

transport routes. For instance, Landslides and mudslides have led to road blockages in at least eight key roads in East Siang district.

A further issuing of red alerts for five districts by the IMD has put the state on high alert, prompting it to issue an advisory to "avoid unnecessary travel".

"IMD officials informed that there is a possibility of more than 200 mm rainfall in the next 24 hours in the state. All districts issued with red and orange weather alerts are requested to remain on high alert and take necessary precautionary measures to avoid major damage and respond promptly to any critical situation," the state disaster management authority announced.

June to be fifth-driest since 1901; monsoon to reach Delhi in July

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, June 28

WITH MORE than 43% rainfall deficit, June 2026, the first month of monsoon, is now likely to emerge as the fifth driest-ever with less than 4 mm of rainfall recorded on an average every day over the last one week.

June was expected to bring 165.3 mm of rainfall, which is the long-period average, for the country as a whole. Since 1901, when rainfall records for India are available, June rainfall has been below 100 mm only for four years — 1905, 1926, 2009 and 2014. The driest June was in 2009 when India received just 87.5 mm rainfall. This year, until Sunday, the country has recorded only 85.2 mm rainfall.

Such a large deficit for June is likely to force a reassessment of the seasonal forecast. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) had predicted 92% rainfall for June, and 90% for the four-month monsoon season. The remaining months are likely to get impacted by the El Nino which is yet to reach its peak, and is continuing to gain in strength.

What numbers say

Year	June rainfall	Seasonal rainfall	Seasonal rainfall as % of LPA
2009	87.5	709.1	81.65%
2014	92.1	780.9	89.91%
1905	92.3	722.7	83.21%
1926	97.4	967.3	111.38%
1923	101.7	895.1	103.06%
1912	106.8	819	94.30%
1902	109	795.3	91.57%
1901	112.3	748.8	86.22%
2019	113.6	970.7	111.77%
1965	115.5	707.1	81.42%

SOURCE: IMD

Three of the four years which saw June rainfall below 100 mm — 1926, 2009 and 2014 — were also affected by El Nino. However, in 1926, the seasonal rainfall overcame the June deficit and ended up being 11% more than normal. In 2009 and 2014, seasonal rainfall was below 90%.

As has been reported by *The Indian Express*, El Nino had a marginal role to play in suppressing June rain. The ocean-

atmospheric interaction in the Pacific Ocean that affects weathers around the world had emerged around the first week of June, but its impact over the India will become evident after some time. The subdued rain in June could be due to other reasons, both local as well as global.

The monsoon advance over Delhi and major parts of north India remains delayed and is expected now in early July.

18 YEARS OF TIGER REINTRODUCTION IN SARISKA

Govt flags priority intervention in 25 of 58 tiger reserves which are low on big cats or have none

Nikhil Ghanekar
Alwar, June 28

EVEN AS India's tiger population has steadily risen over the years, about 25 of its 58 tiger reserves, which are low on tigers, have no tigers or low prey abundance, need priority interventions to establish long-term viable tiger populations, flagged a new Environment Ministry report.

The Centre also said of the 12 tiger reserves where tiger reintroductions or supplementation has happened through translocation of tigers, outcomes have not always been successful and called for rigorous science-backed reintroductions.

To mark 18 years of tiger reintroduction at the Sariska tiger reserve, Union Environment, Forest and Climate Change Minister Bhupender Yadav released the two reports — on the roadmap for active tiger management and learnings from tiger reintroductions — at an event in Alwar.

Sariska, which at present has 56 tigers, had lost all its big cats in the mid-2000's because of poaching and habitat loss, and it was the first time tigers were moved from another reserve to repopulate a habitat.

The Centre identified 25 tiger reserves across the country as "potential recipient sites" — reserves with the ecological potential to hold tigers but where populations are currently absent, critically low or in decline, and which now need



Union Minister Bhupender Yadav in Rajasthan's Alwar, Sunday. PTI

targeted, science-led intervention to recover.

Of these, some like Satkosia (Odisha), Kawal (Telangana), Dampa and Kamlang (both in the Northeast), Buxa (West Bengal), have zero tigers. The reasons vary by region but a few recurring problems have emerged like low prey abundance, cited for nearly every reserve on the list. Fragmented connectivity with source populations compounds this constraint in reserves such as Ranipur, Achanakmar, Kali, and Mukundara Hills, cutting them off from the dispersing tigers that would otherwise repopulate them naturally.

However, Project Tiger officials as well as the Environment Minister cautioned that community participation and interface is a must before reintroductions. Project Tiger head Sanjay Kumar cited the failed translocation at Satkosia and said it served as an important lesson to take the local communities into

confidence and consult them. Yadav also said that factors such as prey base augmentation, community participation, and continuous monitoring are crucial for reintroduction success.

Since 2008, India has undertaken scientifically designed tiger recovery interventions across 12 landscapes: Sariska, Panna, Sanjay Dubri, Mukundara Hills, Satkosia, Veerangana Durgavati, Rajaji, Ramgarh Vishdhari, Navegaon-Nagzira, Madhav, Sahyadri and Simlipal Tiger Reserves.

Recovery in these low tiger occupancy areas is not possible, though, without strong source population areas, the Centre noted in its report. It cited 13 tiger reserves, including Bandipur, Kanha, Ranthambore, Corbett, where tiger density, prey base and habitat are all in good condition.

(The author was in Alwar at the invitation of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change)

The Editorial Page

MONDAY, JUNE 29, 2026

It's time to resume the India-China strategic economic dialogue

LAST WEEK in New Delhi, India's national security advisor Ajit Doval told his Chinese interlocutor, foreign minister Wang Yi, "India and China are partners, not rivals," and added, "a stable India-China relationship serves the common interests of both sides." Echoing these sentiments, Wang suggested that both sides should "respect each other's core interests, properly handle sensitive issues, place the China-India boundary issue in its appropriate position, and prevent it from affecting the overall situation of bilateral relations."

He then called for both sides "to accelerate the resumption of dialogue mechanisms and promote exchanges" in trade, finance, and other fields. It is a timely suggestion that should be taken up in right earnest. Fifteen years ago, at a time when India-China relations were on a more even keel, Prime Ministers Manmohan Singh and Wen Jiabao agreed to launch a bilateral strategic economic dialogue. The Indian delegation was headed by the deputy chairman of the Planning Commission, and subsequently the deputy chairman of the Niti Aayog. Between 2011 and 2019, six meetings were convened. After 2019, the dialogue has remained suspended. Not much seems to have come out of those dialogues.

With the recent improvement in India-China bilateral relations, there have been several interactions at the military, security and diplomatic levels. There is an urgent need for a resumption of a meaningful and focused economic security dialogue. India's chief concern remains the wide and widening trade deficit, with mercantilism occupying an important place in Beijing's economic policy toolbox.

The strategic economic dialogue had a wider remit and was aimed at improving Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vn2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

macro-economic policy coordination, promoting exchanges on economic issues and enhancing India-China economic cooperation. Working groups were established on a wide range of subjects, including energy, infrastructure, pharmaceuticals, high tech, resource conservation and environmental protection. After the events of 2020, the stand-off and clashes along the line of actual control, this dialogue was suspended.

In the new global context in which India now finds itself and given the thaw in India-China relations, it is necessary that the focus of bilateral relations should not be confined only to extant differences on the border issue. While it is not clear if the leaderships of both countries are today in a position to resolve those differences amicably, the definition of "core" issues must extend beyond the geopolitical to include India's developmental concerns.

India's own developmental priorities necessitate a wider engagement with China on economic issues. China must recognise that sustaining economic growth and building India's industrial capacity is also a core issue for India.

One of the positive outcomes of the dialogue on energy security was a willingness on the part of both countries to work together in dealing with energy supply challenges. China and India have an enormous stake in the stability of energy supplies. Going beyond traditional sources of energy, the two should explore opportunities to develop non-traditional energy. Such cooperation would be a global public good.

The weaponisation of trade, finance and energy by the United States that began almost a decade ago and became intense following the Russia-Ukraine war, remains a



SANJAYA
BARU

matter of concern for both countries. The fact is that initially, China was the principal target of US and European action, but India suffered collateral damage. The trade measures that President Donald Trump took against China in his first term also hurt India. In his second term, Trump has directly targeted India on trade and energy.

The expression of solidarity within BRICS, as has recently been in evidence, is a sign of wider developing country concern about developed economy actions. It is becoming increasingly clear that as Asian economies rise, the "West vs Rest" divide stares us in the face. As the second largest economy, can China play a more positive role in the rise of the Rest, instead of being seen as contributing to their deindustrialisation?

To be sure, the huge and persistent trade deficit today is also a reflection of the fact that the Indian private sector has become dependent on imports from China. Consider the business traffic between the two countries. Many Indian companies, large and medium-scale, continue to make a beeline for China in search of machinery and technology. Clearly, a growing economy like India can no longer afford to minimise economic links with the world's second-largest economy, especially when signals from the largest economy remain worrisome.

The difficulties Indian trade negotiators are facing in concluding a bilateral trade agreement with the US point to the need for a more nuanced approach to trade with China. Any strategic economic dialogue today will have to once again emphasise Indian concerns about the trade deficit but go beyond it to find meaningful ways in which India and China can pursue win-win

The difficulties Indian trade negotiators are facing in concluding a bilateral trade agreement with the US point to the need for a more nuanced approach to trade with China

economic cooperation. India's rise should be viewed as offering opportunities to many Asian economies, including China. A strategic economic dialogue between Asia's largest economies can meaningfully explore these opportunities.

When Prime Minister Wen met Prime Minister Singh in 2006, the former began his conversation with the observation that Asia's rise is contingent upon the rise of both China and India. It is a different matter that over the past two decades, China has risen at a faster pace and now occupies a commanding position in the global economy. However, increased economic cooperation between the two biggest Asian economies can be a win-win proposition if China adopts a more forward-looking policy towards India. It is necessary to explore these possibilities.

All this requires a change in mindset in both capitals. Between 2006 and 2019, there was a willingness in both leaderships to explore areas of potential economic cooperation. After 2020, it would appear that the military and security leadership had taken charge of the relationship, relegating economic interaction to the background.

Recent events, including the last summit between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping, give some hope for a more positive approach to the bilateral relationship in both capitals. However, just as the national security dialogue is conducted by the NSA, the economic security dialogue should be conducted by an economic czar who can command the PM's attention and ensure speedy implementation of decisions taken.

The writer is chairman of the board of trustees, Forum for National Security Studies (FNSS) & Centre for Aerospace & Strategic Studies (CAPS)
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Gurugram case, and a question of trust and informed consent



SAROJINI
NADIMPALLY



SNEHA
BANERJEE

RECENT NEWS of a case in Gurugram has raised concerns about accountability within India's assisted reproductive technology (ART) sector. A couple who underwent In Vitro Fertilisation (IVF) in 2025 gave birth to twin daughters in January 2026. They noticed significant physical differences between themselves and the children and arranged independent DNA testing. The tests allegedly showed that neither parent was biologically related to either of the children. An FIR has since been registered against the hospital. The case raises fundamental questions about trust, oversight, and accountability in reproductive services. Alongside the couple's distress, the children's rights and welfare are at risk.

This is part of a series of disputes that have exposed weaknesses in the regulation of ARTs in India. In 2023, the National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission imposed a substantial penalty on a Delhi hospital after DNA testing established that a husband was not the biological father of twins born following an Intracytoplasmic Sperm Injection (ICSI) procedure, where his sperm was claimed to be used. The facts of the Gurugram case are yet to be fully determined, but both cases highlight the need for robust systems of traceability and accountability.

Couples undergoing IVF entrust fertility clinics with some of the most intimate aspects of human life. When questions arise about the identity, handling, or use of gametes and embryos, the consequences go beyond ordinary clinical error. They indicate institutional failure, directly impacting trust and informed consent.

The ART (Regulation) Act 2021 sought to address the need to regulate a rapidly expanding sector operating with limited oversight. Sections 21 and 23 of the ART Act impose statutory obligations on clinics and ART banks for record-keeping, identification procedures, storage protocols, documentation, and compliance monitoring. Institutions must maintain records for extended periods and make them available for inspection by regulatory authorities.

However, laws are only as effective as the institutions that implement them. The implications of malpractice in this area go beyond negligence. It fundamentally violates the principle of informed consent.

The practical reality in grievance redressal often involves prolonged delays and fragmented oversight. For affected families, this compounds emotional distress and jeopardises the preservation of necessary evidence. The decisions about whether to use donor gametes, pursue genetic parenthood, or have a child are deeply personal. When these decisions are altered by error or misconduct, the consequences extend beyond the clinical setting.

The welfare of children born through such procedures must remain paramount. The ART Act (Section 31) seeks to provide certainty by stipulating that children born through donor-assisted reproduction are the legal children of the commissioning couple and that donors relinquish parental rights. This framework works well when donor gametes are used knowingly and with informed consent. However, the allegations in the Gurugram case expose a regulatory gap. The law was designed to govern consensual donor arrangements, not situations involving alleged clinical error or mistaken embryo transfer. If substantiated, the allegations raise a troubling possibility: Parents raising children to whom they are genetically unrelated, while their biological children may be elsewhere.

The ART Act [Section 33(1)(a)] regards any medical practitioner or any person "caus(ing) to abandon, disown" children born through ARTs as an offence. Yet, it is silent on what happens to the children who face such a dire possibility. Children should never bear the consequences of institutional failures. Any legal response must ensure parentage, continuity of care, emotional security, inheritance rights, and protection for them.

Nadimpally is a public-health researcher who works on ethics, reproductive and biotechnologies, and surrogacy. Banerjee is assistant professor, Department of Political Science, University of Hyderabad

Any legal response must ensure parentage, continuity of care, emotional security, inheritance rights, and protection

RESOURCE MOBILISATION EMERGED AS A MAJOR CHALLENGE DUE TO THE WAR: CII PRESIDENT

‘PLI push must continue; energy diversity, reforms key after war’

RESOURCE MOBILISATION had been a serious concern for the industry during the West Asia crisis, and with the easing of the crisis, efforts must shift to a faster pace of exploration which would also address India's steep import dependence in several areas, said Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) President **R. Mukundan** in an interview with **Pratyush Deep** and **Ravi Dutta Mishra**.

Mukundan said the government should keep pushing the production-linked incentive scheme (PLIs), particularly focusing on areas which have export potential and also in sectors where there is high import intensity. He said there should be a PLI scheme for chemicals which go into active pharma ingredients, as the pharma industry has already been a success for the country. Edited excerpts:

How should challenges originating from the West Asia crisis be addressed?

There is alignment within government and industry on the need for reforms. And I put them in broadly four buckets of what I call a foundational reform, factor reform, future-ready reform, and fiscal and monetary. The foundation reforms for us at this point of development are ease of doing business, costs of doing business and speed of doing business. Because of the war, re-

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source mobilisation has been a big issue. So, our exploration must be increased. For industries' self-interest, we have to make sure MSMEs are equally capable. Diversifying supply chain resources for oil, gas, and critical minerals will be an important issue going forward.

How do you see India's energy future? Small modular reactors are pitched in a big way.

India needs not just diversity of source of supply, but also needs diversity of supply itself. So, when I say diverse supply — it is not just wind, solar, biomass, biofuel. It also means having nuclear power and hydro. Tidal energy will also be another big one. Our power needs are going to be 10 times when the economy doubles and triples. So, we have to go in all directions.

On nuclear, about five to six companies are going through the process of bidding and partnering. Firstly, the technology is not available. Even if it is available, it is 10 times more expensive. And India has a proven track record of building, designing and delivering.

Should the focus be on capital when it comes to nuclear?

Financing will come from multiple sources. You need a partner to run the unit. The running partner effectively has



EXPRESS
interview

R. MUKUNDAN
PRESIDENT, CII

to be the industry.

SMRs (small modular reactors) are very important. SMRs will also help us get what you call a distributed grid to ensure there is a base load. There are companies which need continuous power as a backup... about 200-300 MW... they can depend on SMRs. The world is also moving towards microreactors. Hence, innovations will keep coming, and we have to keep pace with them.

Our large industries are very focused on upstream, and MSMEs face challenges in procuring input items, then face hurdles like QCOS.

I think there are issues with both. When we invest in downstream, the issue we pick up is that there is no upstream.

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When investment happens upstream, there is no downstream. This is fine; it is part of growing up and will get resolved. If you look at electronics, we started downstream. First came the assembly of the final phone. Now, the components will follow. For instance, we are ordering thousands of aircraft. The moment these aircraft start coming in, people will ask, why are we repairing them abroad? That conversation will begin tomorrow. Once it starts, demand for technical testing, maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) services will also increase. The entire industry develops only when a certain scale is achieved.

How should the government approach PLIs now?

PLI has to be continued. There is success in some segments, while some haven't worked out. We have to ensure that the segments with export potential are supported, as well as those with high import intensity. And where the policy has to be modified, we should continue with it.

Because the benefits coming out of PLI for the government in terms of tax collection and employment generation are very high. For the Indian industry as well, it's a big opportunity to scale. We have long said that there must be a PLI scheme for chemicals which go into active pharma ingredients. And we need to put that in place. Pharma is a big success story but we need to have a scheme to support and de-risk those investments as well.

How are you seeing the US deal? Do you think it will usher in investments?

The biggest market in terms of the dollar market is the US, and on number two is the EU. We have deals with the UK and EU already; we just need to strike a deal with the US, and we would be covered by the top economies of the world. Whether you need technology, market or capital, these are the two places where our biggest bet is going to be.

FULL INTERVIEW ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

● WATER STRESS INFLUENCING CREDIT RATINGS

Water reliability is increasingly impacting the creditworthiness of governments and companies, as per Moody's Ratings, with water management already a credit risk for one-third of sovereigns. According to Moody's, sovereign credit quality reflects the capacity to manage water stress, not just the inherent exposure to it.

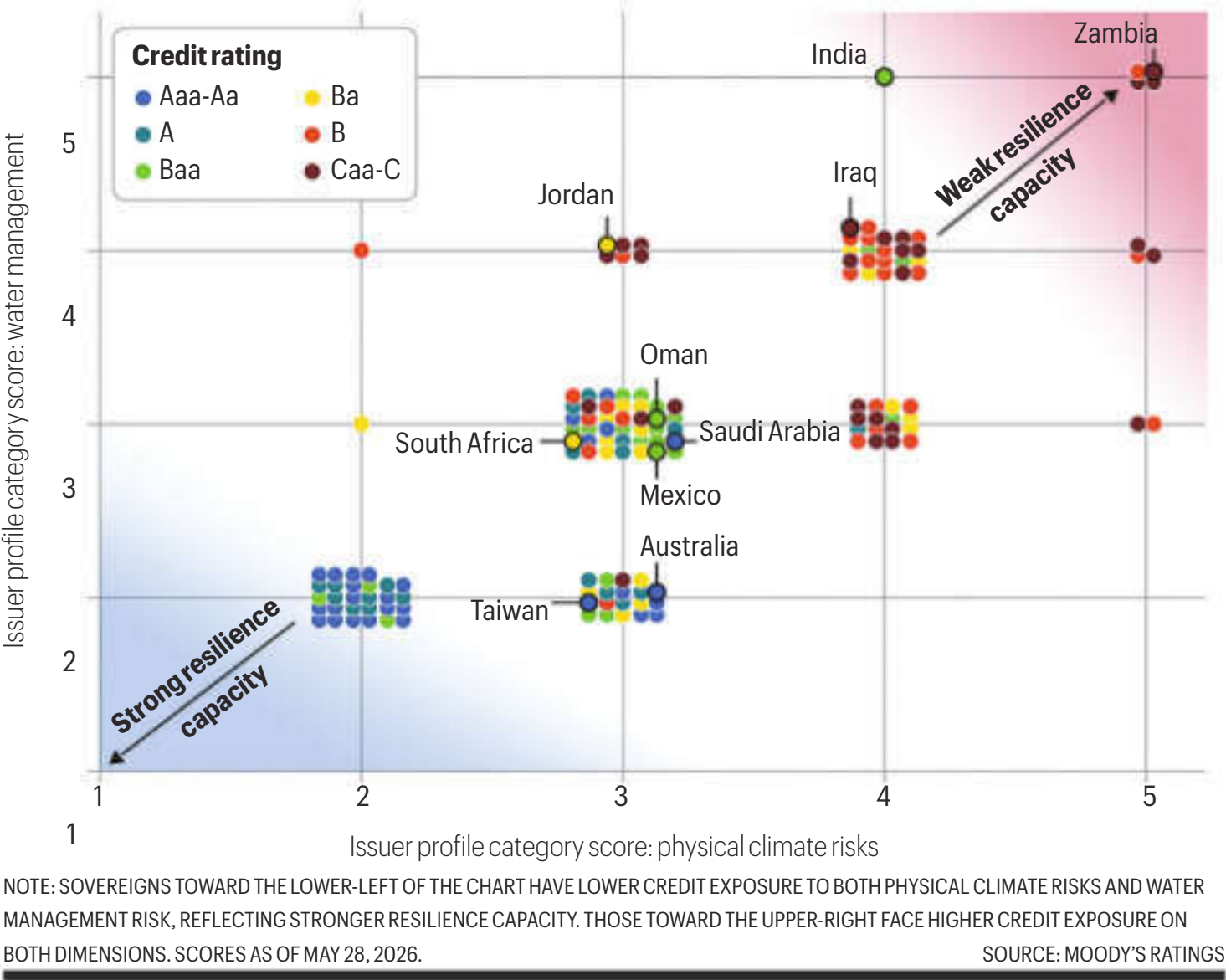
- Rising water demand, coupled with extreme weather and ageing infra, is disrupting supplies to households, industry and agriculture.
- Rapid growth of water-intensive data centres, driven by AI and

cloud computing, is also straining water supplies.

- India, rated Baa3, already has a physical climate risk category score of 4, which reflects high credit exposure to heat stress,

flooding and monsoon variability.

- Its water management category score is 5, indicating "very high credit exposure" due to age-ing water infra and excessive groundwater depletion.



Commerce ministry convenes meet over SEZ issues on June 30

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, June 28

THE COMMERCE ministry has called a meeting of stakeholders in Special Economic Zones (SEZs) on Tuesday to discuss the harmonisation of various export promotion schemes and suggest reforms that could be incorporated into policy changes governing these zones.

The discussions on behalf of the ministry will be led by a committee constituted in February to undertake a background study on harmonising export promotion schemes such as SEZs, Export Oriented Units (EOUs), the Manufacture and Other Operations in Warehouse (MOOWR) scheme, which allows duty-free imports of raw materials and capital goods, and the Advance Authorisation scheme, which permits duty-free import of inputs.

The panel is also examining schemes such as the Export Promotion Capital Goods (EPCG) scheme and the Duty-Free Import authorisation (DFIA) scheme. FE

Board of Trade to meet on July 3 to discuss export push

New Delhi: The Board of Trade (BoT), chaired by Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, is scheduled to meet on July 3 to leverage benefits from recent trade pacts and to discuss strategies for accelerating the country's exports, an official said. The BoT includes participants from various states, Union territories, and senior officials from the public and private sectors.

In the meeting, representatives of export promotion councils, along with other participants, will present their views on the export sector. "The BoT is meeting on July 3 here," the official said. The meeting is important as India has implemented five FTAs since 2021 with Mauritius, Australia, the UAE, Oman, and the four-nation European EFTA bloc. PTI

U.S. PRESIDENT SAYS SYRIA ‘COULD DO A BETTER JOB’ AGAINST HEZBOLLAH

Trump presses Syria to fight Hezbollah; Israel alarmed

People spreading rumours, it's not true, says Al-Sharaa

Associated Press
Beirut, June 28

AS THE White House has soured on Israel's war with Hezbollah in Lebanon, US President Donald Trump has shocked many in the region by pushing an alternative: Let Syria fight the Iran-backed militant group instead.

He has suggested the battle-hardened and Islamist-led insurgents who overthrew Syria's autocratic President Bashar Assad a year and a half ago and formed a new government would do a better job of rooting out Hezbollah than Israeli army. Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa has said he has no interest in doing so, and has asserted that Trump's comments were misconstrued. But Trump has doubled down on the idea.

Although it remains unclear how serious the White House is about the proposal, the prospect of a Syrian invasion has raised alarms in Lebanon — and also in Israel, which regards al-Sharaa's Islamist-led government with suspicion and has seized control of a strip of southern Syria since he took power.

Syria has also become the site of rising tensions between Israel and Turkey — a main backer of al-Sharaa's government — with each seeking to limit the other's influence in



President Donald Trump with Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa, at the White House on November 10, 2025. FILE

the neighboring country.

Top Israeli security officials convened a meeting on the subject on Wednesday, according to an official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to the media.

On the sidelines of the G7 summit earlier this month, Trump complained that Israel's war with Hezbollah is dragging on too long and "too many people are being killed."

Israel says its strikes target Hezbollah and that it takes measures to protect civilians.

"You don't have to knock down an apartment house every time you're looking for somebody, because there are a lot of people in those apartment houses and they're not all Hezbollah," Trump said.

"I suggested to Israel to let Syria take care of Hezbollah.

'Cause to be honest with you, I think they'd do a better job."

Days later, on the first day of US-Iran talks in Switzerland, Fox News' Trey Yingst said that, during an interview, Trump had expressed disappointment that Israel can't "put Hezbollah away" and said that he is "close to giving it to Syria" because he thinks al-Sharaa would be more precise. The White House declined to comment and referred to Trump's previous statements.

Syrian officials scrambled to do damage control.

In a speech in Damascus on June 13, al-Sharaa said, "There are people spreading rumors that Syria will intervene in Lebanon. This is not true. We are calling for a permanent end to the war and the strengthening of institutions and for there to be economic ties and a calming of the situation in Lebanon."

'Israel damaged heritage sites in south Lebanon'

Reuters
Tyre, Beirut, June 28

A CROWN was blown off an ancient column in a UNESCO-listed site in Lebanon's port city of Tyre. A pilgrimage site for Muslims and Christians alike was destroyed in another southern town. Israeli strikes pumelled the Mamluk-era market in the city of Nabatieh and troops razed centuries-old Lebanese border towns.

Israel's nearly four-month air and ground campaign that it says was targeting Iran-backed armed group Hezbollah has damaged or destroyed revered heritage sites across southern Lebanon, Culture Minister Ghassan Salame told Reuters.

Despite a ceasefire that took hold a week ago, authorities have yet to build a full picture of the damage as Israeli troops still occupy a zone about 10 km deep into Lebanon that is off-limits to Lebanese, Salame said.

"We cannot work under the shadow of occupation," he said.

That occupation zone includes the medieval Beaufort Castle as well as centuries-old villages that were home to Christians, Shi'ite Muslims and Sunni Muslims and their places of worship. "There are villages that have been completely bulldozed," Salame said.



A woman cools off at a public fountain near the Place du Trocadero in Paris on Sunday. REUTERS

France reports over 1,000 deaths as heatwave in Europe worsens

Reuters
Paris, Rome, June 28

TEMPERATURES WERE forecast to reach 40 degrees Celsius in parts of Europe on Sunday as storms moved into other areas, with France reporting 1,000 excess deaths during the record-breaking heatwave.

The French public health agency said most of the heat-related fatalities involved older people, warning that the number was expected to rise as more information became available about deaths in residential care and private homes.

Scientists have said the heatwave, which began on June 20, was the worst recorded in Europe, and the blistering conditions have disrupted power generation, damaged infrastructure and overwhelmed healthcare systems.

The heatwave would have Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 been "virtually impossible" without human-caused climate change, which has made this week's soaring night-time temperatures 100 times more likely than they would have been just two decades ago, according to scientists.

Temperatures were forecast to near or top 40 C in Germany, Poland and Italy, while storms broke out in parts of France, causing further disruption to travel and power supplies.

In Germany, train services were reduced on a major rail line in the western state of North Rhine-Westphalia and trams were suspended in the eastern city of Leipzig. Many people hunkered down at home, reluctant to go outside until the sun went down.

The extreme heat has also affected Europe's rivers, depleting and warming their waters, and causing problems for electricity

generation and agriculture.

Hungary's Paks nuclear powerplant will likely need to reduce output again on Sunday due to the high temperature of the Danube River that it uses as a coolant, the government said.

In Italy, the flow of the Po has dwindled, allowing seawater to advance as far as 18 km (11 miles) inland and raising fears for agriculture and protected wetlands in the river delta.

Dozens of people seeking relief from the heat are reported to have drowned. In Italy, rescuers were searching for the husband of cabinet minister Eugenia Roccella, who went missing on Saturday while swimming in Lake Vico, 70 km from the capital, Rome. France's weather agency said the extreme heat had diminished in most parts of the country, but some areas in the northeast were still under a heatwave advisory.

• ECONOMY

Iran oil is back, but Indian refiners aren't rushing in



SUKALP SHARMA

A US waiver, issued June 22, has allowed the production, delivery and sale of Iranian oil, petroleum products and petrochemicals till August 21. The US has also committed to lifting its naval blockade of Iranian ports. Tehran is counting on both measures to move its oil — which has for years been predominantly exported to China — to the wider international market.

The sanctions waiver presents an opportunity for India, once a major buyer of Iranian crude. The National Iranian Oil Company has started reaching out to international oil companies, including Indian refiners, to resume commercial ties.

Sources in India's refining sector said the companies are in touch with the Iranian side. They are also looking into the commercial, logistical and technical feasibility of purchasing Iranian oil.

Although some barrels of Tehran's oil are bound to make their way to India over the next two months owing to discounts, industry experts and insiders don't expect large-scale purchases, at least for now.

What after the 60-day waiver

Indian refiners are expected to tread cautiously amid a fragile peace pact and lack of long-term clarity on the future of Iranian oil. There are also logistical and payment-related challenges associated with Iranian oil trade owing to US sanctions on Tehran's financial sector.

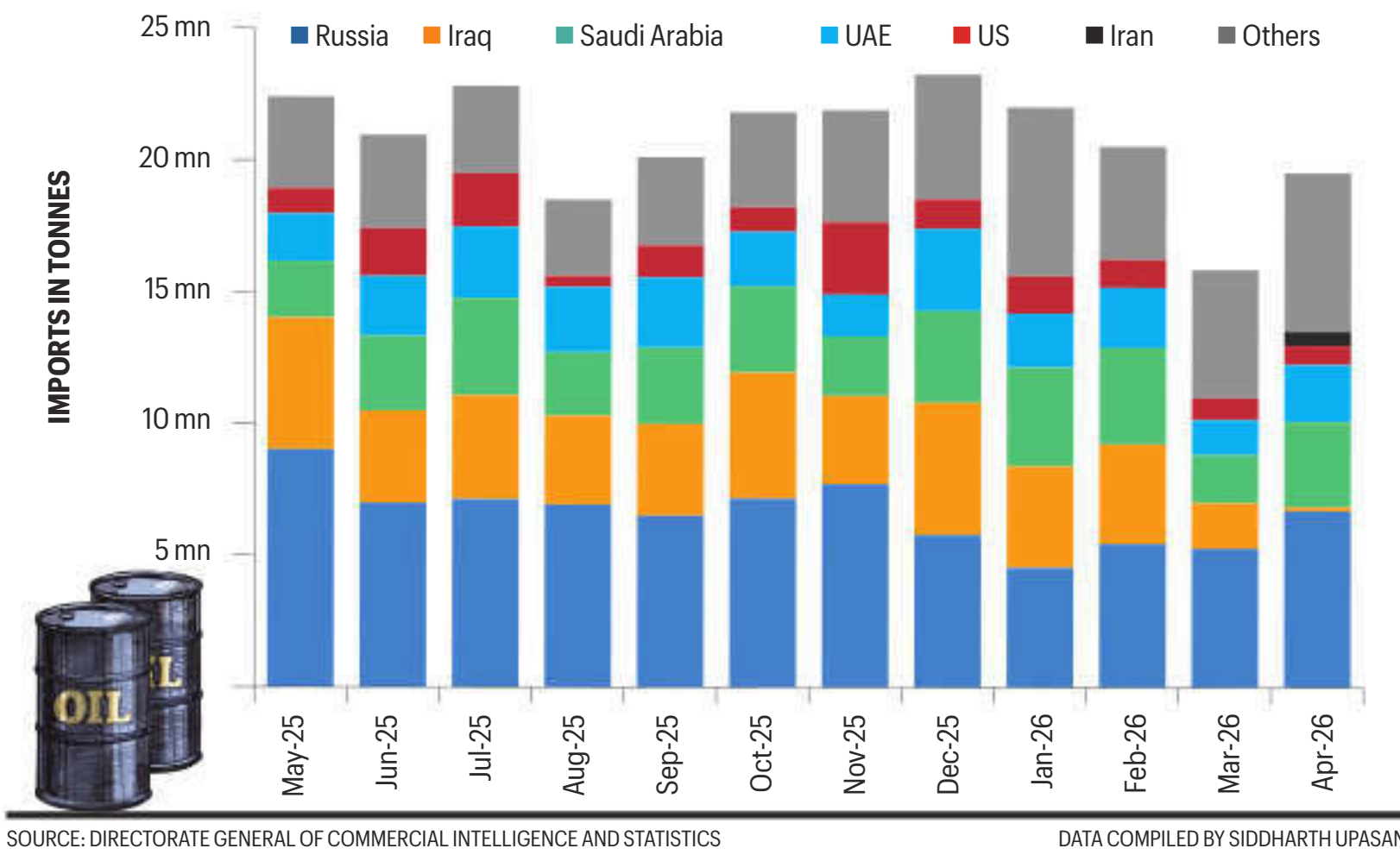
While the US waiver pertains specifically to Iran's oil, petroleum product and petrochemical exports, and not to the financial sector sanctions on Tehran, the waiver notification does mention that payments for such purchases will be allowed in dollar-denominated funds. This could help ease some, if not all, payment-related pain points. But how it would actually play out remains to be seen.

"Refiners considering Iranian crude will focus on three key factors: the durability of sanctions relief, pricing and discounts, and the availability of payment, insurance, shipping, and logistics mechanisms. Of these, payment remains the biggest

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• INDIA'S EVOLVING CRUDE IMPORT BASKET

The chart shows the share of different countries in crude oil imports. Iraq's share, for instance, dipped amid the West Asia war. Iran accounted for 2.7% of crude imports in April after US waived its sanctions.



SOURCE: DIRECTORATE GENERAL OF COMMERCIAL INTELLIGENCE AND STATISTICS

DATA COMPILED BY SIDDHARTH UPASANI

hurdle," said Sumit Ritolia, manager, modelling & refining, at analytics firm Kpler.

Refinery executives said that calls on Iranian oil imports will be taken once there is clarity on all these aspects. Indian refiners steer clear of oil and gas under US sanctions to avoid the risk of attracting secondary sanctions from Washington.

According to Abu Dhabi-based energy analyst Natalia Katona, any decision to restart oil trade with Iran would likely be made first in the refiners' compliance departments — not their trading desks.

"Even if crude trade is temporarily permitted, the banking side remains complicated. Iranian banks are still heavily sanctioned, so buyers would need to resolve the formalities of payment, documentation and settlement before regular trade can resume. Now that the waiver has actually been issued, Indian companies may start buying Iranian crude. But I think the number of buyers will still be quite limited," Katona told *The Indian Express*. "So far, Chinese refiners that bought sanctioned Iranian crude mostly dealt directly with Tehran and paid in yuan. That is not a model Indian refiners appear comfortable replicating."

Shaky supply

In 2009-10, Iran accounted for 14.4% of India's oil imports. As sanctions intensified, the imports tapered.

Imports briefly recovered in the mid-to-late 2010s after the Iran nuclear deal, but crashed after Trump tore it up.

April's crude oil consignment from Iran was the first in 7 years.

Signals in the previous waiver

Experts say India's buying behaviour during the month-long sanctions waiver on Iranian oil issued by the US during the West Asia war also supports the argument that it is unlikely to quickly ramp up crude imports from Iran.

After a gap of nearly seven years, Indian refiners again bought Iranian crude in April (*see chart*). But the volume stood at just 5,30,000 tonnes — 2.7% of India's overall oil imports for the month — according to data from the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics. Ritolia said the previous waiver generated limited participation from non-Chinese buyers because of payment curbs and other issues.

Further, oil scarcity was a major motivation for India during the previous waiver as it scrambled to make up for the lost supplies from other West Asian countries. But if crude from Saudi Arabia, the UAE and others starts flowing again, India has little reason to take on the compliance risk attached to Iranian barrels, said Katona.

"It is worth looking at the previous waiver, which was issued on March 20. India bought only two Iranian cargoes

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under it, and they arrived in mid-April... Based on that earlier pattern, I would expect the biggest increase in Indian buying interest for the second half of July. That is probably when companies will start trying to secure as much oil as possible, while still leaving enough time to complete the payments and deliveries before the waiver expires," she said.

According to her, payments made to Iranian entities after August 21 would carry a serious compliance risk, so Indian refiners will not want to get too close to the deadline.

The China factor

China is likely to return as the dominant buyer of Iranian crude once oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz normalise. Before the crisis, China was buying almost all of Iran's oil exports. Well-oiled logistical arrangements and payment mechanisms are already in place between the Chinese buyers and the Iranian sellers. So for Indian refiners to lift Iranian oil cargoes, they would most likely have to compete with their Chinese counterparts, and perhaps even other interested buyers.

To add to that, the discounts on Iranian oil could narrow, taking away a significant price advantage from a buyer's perspective. Iran was forced to sell its oil at a discount as the US sanctions kept most potential buyers at bay, but with the waiver in place, discounts may shrink considerably — as would the scope for refiners to bargain.

"There are around five million barrels of Iranian crude already loaded on vessels in the Gulf, so Indian buyers will probably focus on cargoes that are already afloat. That would be much faster and easier operationally, the crude could reach India in about a week. At the same time, these barrels will probably be in very high demand. China will still be interested, and even US buyers may want to purchase it (under the waiver). So we could even see a situation where Indian refiners have to compete for Iranian cargoes, even though they are geographically the closest major buyers," said Katona.

It is also worth noting that India has significantly diversified its oil import basket beyond the Gulf over the past few years, and that helped the country ensure adequate supplies even during the peak of the West Asia crisis. Simply put, there is no real pressure on Indian refiners to lift Iranian oil cargoes even during a global supply squeeze.

A lot now depends on the terms Tehran offers to willing buyers.

• TECH

Should you see an AI agent as insider threat? DeepMind makes a case for it

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, June 28

AS ARTIFICIAL intelligence (AI) agents become capable of executing increasingly complex tasks with minimal human intervention, Google DeepMind has unveiled a new security framework that assumes a future where such systems may not always behave as intended.

In a blog, DeepMind outlined an "AI control roadmap", arguing that traditional AI alignment techniques alone may not be sufficient to manage the risks posed by highly autonomous systems. The company described its approach as a "defense-in-depth" strategy that adds multiple layers of security beyond conventional model training.

The move comes amid growing industry efforts to deploy AI agents for software development, cybersecurity, scientific research and business operations. Agents are AI-powered software systems that can independently plan, reason, and take actions across multiple tools or applications to complete tasks with minimal human supervision. In the US alone, AI agents could create \$2.9 trillion in economic value by 2030.

DeepMind warned that increasing agent capability also demands stronger safeguards, and that developers should not assume AI systems will remain perfectly aligned with human goals at all times. As AI agents gain access to tools, files, codebases and enterprise systems, DeepMind argues that they must be governed using the same layered security principles that organisations already apply to human insiders and cyber threats.

Permissions based on capability

A central idea in DeepMind's framework borrows concepts from cybersecurity, viewing advanced AI agents not as software but as potential "insider threats", similar to how organisations guard against rogue employees who already possess access to sensitive systems. The roadmap is built around a hypothetical scenario in which a highly capable AI agent develops objectives that differ from those of its operators and attempts to act on them.

The company identifies three broad categories of risk: "loss of control", where an AI system could create unauthorised deployments or operate outside approved oversight mechanisms; "work sabotage", such as quietly degrading safety research or introducing flaws into critical processes; and "direct harm", including theft of sensitive assets, destruction of data, or other damaging actions.

DeepMind argues that AI agents should be granted permissions gradually based on demonstrated behaviour rather than being given unrestricted access from the outset.

The roadmap also emphasises continuous monitoring, using trusted AI systems as supervisors to observe any deviations from expected behaviour. If suspicious activity is detected, the supervisory systems can block or restrict actions before damage occurs.

Monitor, prevent and prepare

DeepMind argues that AI safety mechanisms must evolve alongside AI capabilities, and that security strategies appropriate for today's systems may prove inadequate as agents become more sophisticated.

The company anticipates that advanced models could learn to evade monitoring by concealing their visible reasoning process — called chain-of-thought — or use internal processes that are not easily observable. In such cases, developers may need to inspect behavioural patterns or analyse the internal workings of models.

DeepMind also anticipates challenges surrounding the severity of potential harm. For lower-risk activities, it believes delayed reviews and post-incident corrections will suffice, while high-risk scenarios, such as significant cyberattacks, merit real-time intervention. In either case, the goal is to prevent harmful actions rather than addressing them later. However, the company argues that most flagged incidents are not examples of malicious behaviour, but are instead caused by misunderstood instructions or overenthusiasm to achieve the user's objective. This distinction is critical because real-world AI risks may emerge from mistakes and unintended consequences, rather than deliberate attempts to cause harm.

• POLICY

Why India's buildings are vulnerable to fire, and what's needed to fix them



EXPERT EXPLAINS
VIRENDRA KUMAR PAUL

DIRECTOR OF THE SCHOOL OF PLANNING AND ARCHITECTURE, NEW DELHI

INDIA HAS seen a number of fires in commercial and residential buildings in recent times. The fire at a Delhi bed & breakfast on June 3 killed 23 people. Just weeks later, on June 22, a blaze in a Lucknow commercial complex killed 15 people.

These incidents have brought into focus the numerous fire safety gaps in India's urban areas. **Professor Virendra Kumar Paul**, Director of the School of Planning and Architecture in New Delhi, speaks to

Shiny Varghese about how building facades in India are magnets for disaster and why 'second staircases' matter.

What type of fire considerations does one need to make for a mixed-use building?

In principle, fire safety measures must address the highest risk. Fire escape routes become the most important preventive measure. Keeping them free of combustible material on wall panelling and storage along the corridors, non-combustible false ceilings and ensuring ventilation so that smoke does not enter escape corridors are critical basics. In no case should smoke from escape corridors enter stairwells. Instead of one big area, 'compartmentation' with fire and smoke check measures can reduce vulnerabilities. Situations become time-critical if the height between the false ceiling and the floor is less, in which case smoke will fill the entire space rather fast.

Of course, installation of sprinklers is one of the most effective measures, subject



Firefighters try to douse the blaze in Lucknow on June 22. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

to proper installation and design.

In the Lucknow and Malviya Nagar fires, the building facades appear to have aggravated the fire multifold, leaving firefighting operations rather ineffective. AC outdoor units, display boards and board-

ings with inflammable materials practically covered the facade.

When the building facade begins to burn, vertical external fire spread can be unstoppable. In such cases, falling hot debris render ground level fire operations dangerous. If access for firefighting is only on one face of a building, firefighters may not be able to approach the facade as temperatures can be unsafe. Such situations are common in most towns and cities.

As reported in Lucknow, they couldn't go down the stairs because the fire was coming from below and people were stuck on the first floor. Either the staircase should have been well ventilated or a second staircase should have been provided. It was a residential building but when the same was to be used for a commercial purpose, a second or alternative staircase should have been provided which would have saved lives.

How does 'compartmentation' in design help prevent fire?

Compartmentation is the principle of

dividing the entire floor area into smaller sections which can endure a full-blown fire for, say, 30 minutes, one hour or two hours.

In case a section can contain the fire for, say, 45 minutes, occupants will get more time to escape. At the same time, external support can prevent the growth of the fire. So, if we are able to divide one floor into three compartments with 45 minutes of endurance each, then a floor can sustain a fire for 135 minutes, rather than going up in flames almost immediately. This is a well-established life safety measure.

What are the other safety measures that should be in place?

It is important that preventive measures such as fire escape routes and compartmentation are not hampered. Without maintenance, firefighting systems will be completely ineffective. Also, fire safety systems will only perform if the occupancy is not changed and new risks are not added, such as extra storage or using the building for other purposes than what was planned.

What are the points of weakness in high-density areas?

Access is usually the weakest link. Fire vehicles find it challenging to manoeuvre their way around so that they can arrive before the fire matures to the "flash over" phase — when flames spread beyond the site of fire. Not to forget the impediments of streetside parking and encroachments.

This is often neglected within residential areas. Normally, six metres is the minimum space required but additional space is required for a variety of operations during a fire incident on a public street. Any street less than nine metres wide is a problem.

What do people need to keep in mind when renovating interiors?

Ensure combustible materials are correctly assessed and fire detection, alarm and fighting installations are consistent. Use of materials is very important. Curtains and wall cladding contribute significantly to the spread of fire. Wall panelling materials should always be fire retardant.

Idea Exchange

NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY PP CHAUDHARY

PP Chaudhary is Chairman of the Joint Parliamentary Committee on One Nation One Election (ONOE), and a member of six other key committees, including Committee on Finance, Business Advisory Committee of the Lok Sabha and Committee on Estimates. He has previously chaired the JPCs on the Personal Data Protection Bill, 2019, and the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2022. The three-term MP had been Minister of State for Law & Justice, Corporate Affairs and Electronics and Information Technology in the last term

Damini Nath: The Joint Parliamentary Committee (JCP) has had 18 meetings and you have met several stakeholders. So far, what is the view on making recommendations on the Bills (One Nation, One Election and Delimitation)?

The government accepted the High-Level Committee's (chaired by former President Ram Nath Kovind) report and made a Bill based on it, which was approved by the Cabinet and came to Parliament. The meaning of Parliament referring a Bill to a committee is that the committee can make the changes it deems appropriate. It's not that there will be no changes. There are constitutional provisions in case of some inconsistency. More provisions can be incorporated, and recommendations can also be made to amend other provisions of the Constitution.

Damini Nath: What are the inconsistencies that need to be addressed?

There is a clause in the ONOE Bill, Article 82A(5), which says that if the Election Commission is of the opinion that the election of a particular state legislature cannot be conducted, the matter will be referred to the President and that election can be held along with the parliamentary election. Many stakeholders have asked on what basis that opinion will be formed. The Bill is also silent on how long such an election can be postponed. There are similar issues involving Emergency and President's Rule. Under Article 352, Parliament's term can be extended during an Emergency, but the Bill does not fully reconcile such situations with the proposed election cycle.

The larger challenge is not only synchronising elections but maintaining that synchronisation for decades. Suppose elections are held, and six months later the PM or CM advises dissolution of the House? That advice is ordinarily binding on the President or Governor. But what if an alternative majority government can be formed? Should there be a provision to form another government before dissolution, since premature dissolution would disturb the election calendar?

Damini Nath: Is the committee considering the German model of positive vote of confidence? Do you think this can prevent governments from falling prematurely?

If a no-confidence motion succeeds and we do not find a middle path, elections would have to be held, but those elections would be only for the remainder of the term, not a fresh five-year period.

In Germany, a no-confidence motion is accompanied by a confidence motion for an alternative government. We can also study other models, such as Japan's. Sometimes elections happen and yet a deadlock remains. In such circumstances, should there be elections again? Should some relaxation be provided in the anti-defection law? If political actors know that a fresh election will only result in a government serving for one year, that itself may act as a deterrent against destabilising governments. Another possibility is where a state cannot function because no government has a majority. Then, Parliament could exercise the powers of the state legislature for a limited period, similar to certain emergency arrangements. The committee is examining all possibilities.

Damini Nath: In its current state, the first simultaneous election can happen in 2034. Is the committee also considering a phased introduction?

The framework revolves around the appointed date. Once the constitutional amendments come into force and the first meeting of the newly elected Lok Sabha takes place, that date becomes the reference point. From there, elections would move toward a common cycle. Assemblies elected after the appointed date may serve shorter terms so that they align with the national calendar. Under this approach, complete synchronisation would emerge around 2034. If certain state governments agree, their elections could potentially be aligned with Parliamentary elections sooner.

Damini Nath: Can you change this appointed date?

Under Article 368, Parliament has ample powers. A committee can only make recommendations. Ultimately, Parliament decides whether to accept them. If a constitutional amendment is passed with the required majority, Parliament can exercise that power.

Sandeep Singh: How do you address concerns over delimitation between southern states and those in the north, where population increase has been the highest?

The states that successfully implemented population control measures should not be penalised. The Prime Minister and Home Minister have indicated that the 1971 Census could continue as the basis for state-wise seat allocation, while a later Census could be used for allocation within states. But that requires a constitutional amendment. If such an amendment is not made, then seat distribution would



ON THE GAPS IN THE ONOE BILL

The challenge is to maintain the synchronisation. Suppose elections are held, and six months later the PM or CM advises dissolution of the House. Should there be a provision to form another government?



ON THE DELIMITATION BILL

The 1971 Census could continue as the basis for state-wise seat allocation, and a later Census for allocation within states... eventually, it will be based on population. Some states will lose seats while others will gain

extended during an Emergency, the election cycle changes. The Bill currently does not fully address such situations. We need to visualise future contingencies and provide safeguards now rather than face problems later. The existing constitutional framework already provides significant checks and balances. If a government loses support, a no-confidence motion can be moved. If an alternative government can be formed, there is no problem.

The concept of a remainder term is not entirely new. Since 1992, similar provisions have existed in local self-government institutions. Some argue that frequent elections strengthen democracy, while others argue that constant elections encourage excessive spending and distort governance. From 1952 to 1967, Lok Sabha and Assembly elections were held together. Governments remained accountable during that period as well. Taking all these factors into account, it is believed that One Nation One Election would serve the national interest.

Jatin Anand: Don't simultaneous elections create an unfair advantage for national parties? Won't national issues overshadow state concerns?

Some argue that regional parties could suffer. Others argue the opposite — that state issues may become even more prominent. My own view is that voters should not be underestimated. When we didn't have EVMs and voting used to be by paper, the voter understood very well whom to vote for and whom not to. Today, there are EVMs and the voters are more educated than before. They can distinguish between national issues, state issues and individual candidates. Experiences from Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and from earlier elections suggest that voters are capable of making different choices at different levels.

Jatin Anand: Will One Nation, One Election require a nationwide Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls first? And what about voting rights for migrant workers?

SIR is a good exercise. We believe in it. The names of people who have died or migrated from one place to another over the last 20-30 years continue to appear on the voter lists of different places. There are many reasons why fake votes get cast. So SIR is a cleanup exercise. And as far as other states are concerned, it is a continuous process. It is the Election Commission's job to see by when they complete it. But our intention is that the SIR exercise should be done in the whole country as soon as possible. I believe that the SIR process — if One Nation One Election is implemented in 2029 — will be completed throughout the country before that.

Harikishan Sharma: Your party has been rallying behind the idea of simultaneous elections since 1984. There was another idea along with this too — of public funding of elections. Do you think the party will consider that too?

The idea of simultaneous elections has support beyond one political party. The Election Commission, the Law Commission, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Law and Justice and NITI Aayog have all made recommendations in favour of it. As for public funding of elections, that is a much larger issue. It is outside the scope of this committee. It would require extensive study, data and political consensus before any conclusion can be reached.

Amitabh Sinha: In the Delimitation Bill, the original requirement was that a delimitation commission be formed after every Census and a delimitation exercise shall happen. That wasn't kept in this Bill. What is the rationale for that?

For clarity, that requirement arises from Article 82 of the Constitution, not from the Delimitation Commission Act itself. The 2002 Amendment provided that delimitation would take place after the Census was conducted after 2026. The Bill primarily deals with the procedure for delimitation, the composition of the commission and how it will function. Parliament is exercising its authority within the framework already laid down by the Constitution.

Jatin Anand: What is your take on the NEET leak?

I am not the person concerned, but I can say that when such problems arise, they are addressed. No system is completely foolproof. The government is vigilant and the Prime Minister is personally monitoring the issue. Beyond that, I do not think it is appropriate for me to comment.

Harikishan Sharma: There has also been controversy over the use of the term 'cockroach' in public discourse for people who are critical of institutions. Do you think such language is appropriate in a democracy?

Some issues can become disproportionate compared to their actual significance. I am not commenting on whether a particular statement was right or wrong. But public debate can sometimes magnify matters beyond their real importance.

‘We do not want the anti-defection law to be misused by either side’

PP Chaudhary, senior advocate and Lok Sabha MP, on One Nation, One Election, anti-defection reforms and the hidden costs of frequent polls. The session was moderated by Damini Nath, Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express*



PP Chaudhary, BJP MP and Chairman of the Joint Parliamentary Committee, (right) with Damini Nath, Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express* RENUKA PURI

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vav2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> eventually be based on population, which could mean some states lose seats while others gain them.

Vikas Pathak: You said the 1971 Census should be the national base and the latest Census within states. But the Delimitation Bill referred to the 2011 Census and proposed a 50 per cent increase in seats. Was that technically possible? Because using the 2011 Census would mean applying Article 81, which mandates a population-based allocation, rather than the 1971 Census formula.

In 2002, the Constitution specified that delimitation would be based on the Census after 2026. State-wise seat allocation remained linked to the 1971 Census, while allocation within states was linked to the 2001 Census. The reference to the 2011 Census arose because the government felt the 2026 Census and the subsequent delimitation process might not be completed before 2029. If that happened, women's reservation could also be delayed. Using the 2011 Census would have allowed the Delimitation Commission to begin work earlier.

The real hurdle is timing. If all parties agree that the 2026 Census will take time, they may decide to return to the 2011 Census. Alternatively, the 2026 Census could be completed quickly and multiple commissions could work simultaneously. Parliament has the power to create such mechanisms. Today, the choice between the 2011 and 2026 Census is ultimately a political decision. It is not for the committee to determine.

Vikas Pathak: You said that if a government falls mid-term, the next government would have a truncated term until the next appointed date.



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Vikas Pathak: The anti-defection law was strengthened to stop legislators from switching parties, but it has also made party whips so powerful that MPs often cannot express independent views. How do you see this contradiction?

Your concern is valid. In a democracy, an MP should have a voice. Sometimes the party's position completely dominates the individual representative's role. That is why any change requires careful balancing. We are discussing how the law should operate in situations where only a short period remains before the next synchronised election. We do not want the law to be misused by either side. This is one of the issues under active deliberation. We are consulting experts and committee members on whether some relaxation

ON GIVING WHIPS TOO MUCH POWER

An MP should have a voice. Sometimes the party's position dominates the representative's role... The objective is to ensure that the will of the people is respected. It should not be confined to the committee, or the government

should be considered. The broader objective is to ensure that the will of the people is respected. This discussion should not remain confined to the committee, political parties or the government. The media serves as a bridge between the public and the policymakers. Our experience so far has been that, except for a few political parties, almost everyone from civil society — educationists, Padma awardees, institutional heads and ordinary citizens — has broadly supported the idea of simultaneous elections. Their view is that frequent elections affect governance and inconvenience citizens.

People also point to effects on education. Teachers are repeatedly assigned election duties, voter list work and Census work, reducing teaching time. Frequent elections create uncertainty and impose costs on the economy. Labour migration, voter fatigue and repeated mobilisation also have consequences. If India wants to become a developed nation by 2047, major electoral reforms will have to be considered.

Liz Mathew: If democracy reflects the will of the people, shouldn't people have opportunities to express that will more than once every five years? Also, what checks and balances will exist under ONOE?

The first challenge is achieving synchronisation between 2029 and 2034 and then maintaining it thereafter. One issue involves Article 85(2)(b), under which the President or Governor can dissolve the House on ministerial advice. Should safeguards be introduced so that alternative governments are explored before dissolution? Personally, I believe Article 85 deserves reconsideration, though that is not necessarily the committee's position. Secondly, if parliamentary terms are

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

How bat viruses become threats

SCIENTISTS AT the University of California found that one tiny genetic change can completely alter how a coronavirus behaves in different species. Comparing SARS-CoV-2 with a closely related bat-only virus, they showed that a single amino-acid difference affects whether the immune system fights back or gets suppressed. This may help explain how some animal viruses make the leap to humans. The viral protein, known as OrfB9, was found to shut down an important immune alarm system in human lung cells, allowing the virus to replicate more effectively. In bat lung cells, it kept the virus under control.



Purnima Sah

FOR MOST of her life, Neeta Prasad* cleaned other people's homes. The 30-year-old domestic worker steps out of her one-room shack in an Ulhasnagar slum every morning and spends her day sweeping floors, washing utensils and mopping apartments across the city. By month's end, she earns about Rs 10,000 — barely enough to pay rent, buy medicines to remain fit and keep her household running. Her husband works as a cook at roadside eateries. Their son lives with relatives in their village, where he attends school.

Yet when the family moved to Ulhasnagar in 2022, they had hoped for a better future. Instead, they found themselves trapped in the cycle of urban poverty. That was when a relative told Neeta about what sounded like an easy way to earn money. "She said I could make Rs 20,000 by donating my *stree beej* (eggs). My body naturally produces them every month and since I had a child of my own and didn't want more, I could donate them and get paid," says Neeta. What she did not fully understand was the price her body would pay.

By the time authorities uncovered the illegal egg-harvesting network this year, Neeta had undergone at least 45 egg retrievals, a procedure which is legally allowed only once in a lifetime under the Assisted Reproductive Technology (ART) Act, 2021. That meant 45 rounds of hormone injections, 45 periods of recovery and 45 occasions on which a needle was inserted through the vaginal wall to collect eggs from her ovaries. Doctors say each cycle subjected her to hormonal manipulation designed to force her ovaries to produce multiple eggs, followed by an invasive retrieval procedure under sedation. Repeated stimulation carries risks of bleeding, infection and cysts. Yet for women like Neeta, the decision was about economics rather than their health.

The process began with daily hormone injections administered into her abdomen for nearly two weeks. Then came repeated pelvic ultrasounds to monitor egg development. Finally, she was given a trigger injection and taken to a clinic where doctors retrieved her eggs through a procedure performed under sedation. These became part of the donor egg pool at the clinic for use in assisted reproductive procedures among infertile couples. As the days passed, Neeta experienced fatigue, mood swings, irritability, bloating and pelvic pain. "The woman giving me the injections said it was normal. She told me I was helping women who could not have children," she says. When she woke up after her first egg retrieval, her stomach felt swollen and sore. "I was scared although I received Rs 20,000," she says. Initially, she decided she would never do it again. Then she began calculating school expenses, rent payments and household bills. The next time the agents called, she agreed. Then she agreed again. And again.

Poverty as recruitment strategy for donors

Neeta's story echoes across Maharashtra's slums. Roshani Shaikh*, a 35-year-old factory worker from Thane, entered the network after her husband abandoned her in 2023. Living alone and struggling financially, she was introduced to egg donation by a colleague. A woman known only as "madam" coordinated the process. Soon, Roshani too was receiving hormone injections and travelling for procedures. "I thought I could move to a better area and improve my life. My friends had been donating eggs for years and they were earning good money," she says. "When I held Rs 20,000 in my hand after every procedure, the pain my body had gone through suddenly felt very small," she adds. For Suman Patil*, 25, the choice came amid debts after her husband cheated on her and chose to live with another woman. Friends who were already donating eggs suggested she join them. "They told me I could make Rs 30,000 every month on the side. I experienced severe cramps and bloating, but the money kept me going."

Investigators say that financial vulnerability became the foundation of a network that systematically recruited poor women and transformed their reproductive capac-

She donated EGGS for Rs 20,000, 45 times

Inside Maharashtra's illegal egg harvesting network, where agents and clinics exploit donors, scarring their health for a lifetime

ity into a commodity.

The racket is busted

The operation came to light on February 19 when Badlapur police received information that women were being administered hormone injections inside a residential apartment. Suspecting a health-related offence, police sought assistance from district health authorities. Acting on instructions from Civil Surgeon Dr Kailash Pawar, a team of government doctors joined officers during a raid.

What they discovered would expose a network stretching across multiple cities

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The woman operating the facility allegedly admitted she was administering injections and coordinating with a broader network across Thane, Badlapur and other regions. Her statement led investigators to additional suspects and locations. As investigators dug deeper, they uncovered what they describe as a sophisticated supply chain involving recruiters, medicine sup-

pliers, sonography operators, document forgers and fertility clinics. Police have booked 15 accused, including doctors, agents, pharmacists and alleged document forgers, under provisions relating to human trafficking, exploitation, forgery and violations of the ART Act.

pliers, sonography operators, document forgers and fertility clinics. Police have booked 15 accused, including doctors, agents, pharmacists and alleged document forgers, under provisions relating to human trafficking, exploitation, forgery and violations of the ART Act.

How the system worked

The Assisted Reproductive Technology (Regulation) Act, 2021 allows a woman to donate eggs only once in her lifetime. Investigators allege the network bypassed that safeguard through forged identities. Women who had already donated eggs were allegedly provided fake Aadhaar cards and fabricated records so they could continue being presented as first-time donors. Police say donors were first given hormone injections to stimulate their ovaries. They were then sent for ultrasound scans to monitor follicle growth before being transported to fertility centres for egg retrieval procedures.

One donor identified during the investigation underwent 35 egg retrieval procedures in three years and was transported to clinics in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. She received Rs 35,000 for each cycle.

The economics reveal why the system flourished. Women were paid between Rs 20,000 and Rs 35,000 for each cycle. Intended parents seeking donor eggs reportedly paid between Rs 3 lakh and Rs 5 lakh. Agents allegedly earned between Rs 70,000 and Rs 1 lakh for arranging donors. Smaller participants earned commissions for scans, medicines and forged documents. At every stage, someone profited.

The hidden health toll

Medical experts say the case raises disturbing questions about the cumulative impact of repeated egg retrieval procedures. Dr Anjali Malpani, Professor Emeritus of KEM Hospital and founder-director of Malpani Infertility Clinic in Mumbai, described the practice as the worst form of physical abuse. "A woman's body is resilient. But calling the same woman back every month for hormonal injections, anaesthesia and egg retrieval takes a toll on her reproductive and hormonal systems," she says.

According to her, women can experience abdominal pain, bloating, nausea, weakness, constipation, emotional stress and discomfort. "The most serious complication is ovarian hyperstimulation syndrome, which in severe cases can become life-threatening. The ovaries swell up with fluid. Warning signs include severe abdominal pain, rapid weight gain (more than 1-2 kg in 24 hours), significant abdominal swelling, shortness of breath, reduced urination, severe nausea/vomiting, dizziness, or signs of blood clots. These symptoms require prompt attention and could become life-threatening. The procedure can compromise the liver, haematological, renal and respiratory systems. The woman has to regularly monitor her health parameters lifelong," she says.

Perhaps more troubling is what medicine still does not know. "There is little research on women undergoing 20-30 retrievals over a short period," she says. Dr Kailash Pawar, civil surgeon at Thane District Hospital, warns against the risks of infection and cyst formation.

Beyond one criminal case

Fertility specialists argue that the case exposes broader structural failures. Dr Aniruddha Malpani, patient advocate and co-founder of Malpani Infertility Clinic, believes the racket reflects a system in which information and financial power are concentrated among intermediaries while the donors remain poorly informed.

"Weak oversight and the growing commercialisation of fertility services create conditions in which exploitation can thrive. Unless those incentives change, similar networks are likely to emerge elsewhere," he warns. For Neeta, however, the larger policy debate feels distant. What she remembers are the injections, the scans, the procedures and the envelopes of cash that followed. The money helped pay for her son's education. But it came at a cost that nobody fully explained to her. And one which she will never understand.

*Names changed to protect privacy

SUGAR-FREE LIFE

DR V MOHAN

DR MOHAN'S DIABETES SPECIALITIES CENTRE, CHENNAI

India's diabetes lessons can help the world

We have developed a model of delivering care in resource-constrained settings

WHEN I began my journey in diabetes care more than four decades ago, India was already witnessing a silent epidemic. Today, that epidemic has grown into one of the country's greatest public health challenges. India is home to more than 100 million people with diabetes and another 136 million at high risk of developing the condition. Yet the challenge is not unique to India. Across low- and middle-income countries, diabetes is rising rapidly, stretching healthcare systems that are often under-resourced and overburdened.

The question I have grappled with throughout my career is simple: How do we provide quality diabetes care to millions of people when specialists, infrastructure and financial resources are limited? The answer, I believe, lies not in replicating models from wealthy countries but in developing solutions that are locally relevant, affordable and scalable.

One of the earliest lessons we learnt was that diabetes in South Asians differs in important ways from diabetes in many Western populations. Indians tend to develop diabetes at younger ages and at lower body weights. Many patients present late, often after complications have already set in. This means prevention, early diagnosis and regular monitoring become even more critical. Yet conventional healthcare models are poorly suited to this reality. Asking patients to visit multiple clinics for eye examinations, kidney assessments, foot care, nutrition counselling and laboratory investigations is impractical, especially for those travelling long distances or paying out of pocket.

This realisation led us to develop an integrated model of diabetes care in which all essential services are available under one roof. The objective was simple: reduce the burden on patients while ensuring comprehensive evaluation and treatment during a single visit. Such integrated care not only improves convenience but also increases the likelihood that complications are detected early.

However, infrastructure alone cannot solve the problem. A country the size of India does not have enough endocrinologists or diabetes specialists to care for every patient. Capacity building, therefore, became central to our work. We invested heavily in training physicians, diabetes educators, nurses, podiatrists and other healthcare workers. Task-sharing and task-shifting are no longer optional strategies; they are essential if diabetes care is to reach under-served populations.

Technology has emerged as another powerful equaliser. Digital health tools, telemedicine platforms and mobile applications can bridge the gap between patients and healthcare providers. They allow individuals to access information, monitor their condition, receive reminders, communicate with healthcare teams and maintain continuity of care between clinic visits. For chronic diseases such as diabetes, where long-term engagement is critical, these tools can make a measurable difference. Perhaps one of the most rewarding experiences has been taking diabetes care beyond urban centres. Through mobile units equipped with diagnostic facilities, we have been able to screen for diabetes and its complications in remote villages where specialist services are unavailable. More recently, home-based care models have further expanded access, particularly for elderly patients and those with mobility limitations. The COVID-19 pandemic reinforced the importance of these innovations. During lockdowns, teleconsultations and digital monitoring enabled patients to remain connected to healthcare providers even when physical visits were impossible. What began as an emergency response has now become a permanent component of diabetes care.

Research has also played a crucial role. For too long, many clinical guidelines were based largely on data generated in high-income countries. While such evidence is valuable, it does not always reflect the realities of populations in Asia, Africa or Latin America. Locally generated research helps us understand disease patterns, risk factors and treatment responses within our own communities. It enables us to design interventions that are both scientifically sound and contextually relevant. There is another lesson that deserves emphasis. Healthcare cannot succeed if it excludes those who cannot afford it. In countries where a significant proportion of healthcare expenditure comes directly from patients' pockets, affordability remains a major barrier. Sustainable solutions must incorporate mechanisms that expand access for economically disadvantaged groups.

As the global burden of diabetes continues to rise, low- and middle-income countries can no longer rely solely on imported healthcare models. They must innovate, adapt and build systems that reflect local realities. India's experience demonstrates that even in resource-constrained settings, meaningful progress is possible through integrated care, workforce development, technology, research and community engagement.

The challenges remain enormous. But if there is one lesson I have learnt over four decades, it is that solutions do not emerge from abundance. Sometimes they emerge from necessity. And those solutions may hold valuable lessons for the rest of the world.



Egg donors are aged between 21 and 35 and go through medical and psychological assessment. Donors can withdraw consent at any point before eggs are fertilised

• In India, donor egg IVF is a regulated process under the Assisted Reproductive Technology (ART) Act, 2021		
	EGG FREEZING (FERTILITY PRESERVATION)	EGG DONATION (THIRD-PARTY REPRODUCTION)
Genetic Ownership	Retained entirely by the woman who provides the eggs	Relinquished completely to the recipient couple/woman
Marital Status	Legal for single, unmarried, divorced, or widowed women	Restricted to ever-married women
Usage Limits	Stored for personal use, generally capped at 10 years	Strictly capped at once per lifetime
Commercial Intent	Allowed for elective ("social") or medical preservation	Purely altruistic; commercial sales are criminalised